my first long stint away from home on my own and it wasn't easy coming from such a different cultural background, but the generosity and openness of my employers made the stay immensely enriching and it was a great learning experience, to put it mildly.

One of the first problems was that I had little idea of the roads and had to follow my team-mate Richard Blakey as he drove to the ground. I was not really used to driving in England and often opted for the fastest lane while driving to the ground. There were occasions when I missed an exit and also lost Richard in the process. It was difficult to turn back and I cursed myself for not staying in the slowest lane, where it would have been easier to see the exit. There were no mobile phones then and getting lost meant I would be late for practice, which I hated.

I had actually driven a little in England in 1991 when I was there to play a few games of league cricket. Back then I stayed with the former India fast bowler Atul Wassan and he was generous enough to give me his car to drive around. He asked me if I had driven before and I assured him that I had passed all the tests and had an international licence and was confident of my driving skills. He said the key to driving in the UK was not to use the brake much and just to follow the lanes. However, the very first day ended in disaster. I was in the fast lane when all of a sudden the car came to a halt. There was no power and the car would not restart, and I panicked when I saw a string of cars behind me. I told Atul, '*Gadi start nahi ho raha hai yaar!*' (The car is not starting, my friend!) Atul initially thought I was joking and asked me to accelerate. Anxious, I said to him that I was trying to, but there was no power and nothing was working. Only then did we realize that we had run out of fuel. Atul immediately asked me to put on the hazard lights and in my state of nervousness it took me ages to find the switch in the unfamiliar car. Finally, Atul put on the hazard lights for me. Somehow we got the car onto the hard shoulder, then we called the AA and after a while a breakdown vehicle arrived.

Another problem was my complete lack of knowledge of English geography, which caused a number of blunders during my stay in Yorkshire. Some of these I now remember with fondness. One such was to commit myself to playing at opposite ends of the country on consecutive days. I had agreed to play in an India–Pakistan festival match in London but had also committed to playing for a Rest of the World XI versus England at Newcastle the following day. To add to my